

The Santhals.—There are 97,836 Santhals in Hazaribagh district according to the Census of 1951. The Santhals speak the Santhali language. Many Santhals also speak the Bengali language. They usually understand some form of *gawari Hindi* or colloquial Hindi as spoken in the district. The Santhali language has no script of its own. The foreign missionaries had introduced the Roman script and had published books, scriptures, collection of Santhali folk-songs, stories, etc., in Santhali language but in Roman script. There has been a recent innovation by the introduction of Devanagari script for publishing books in Santhali language. The Government of Bihar have been publishing a news-sheet "*The Hor-Sambad*" in Santhali language in Devanagari script.

The Santhali language has been described as a rich language. Bodding, who spent many years in the Santhal Parganas as a missionary has made researches into the grammatical aspects of the language besides other foreign missionaries. Their books still remain as the most authoritative literature on Santhali language.

It is note-worthy that although there was no written script for Santhali language human memory as in the case of other tribes like the Mundas and the Oraons had kept up a fund of stories, riddles, folk-songs, proverbs, idioms and sayings handed down from generation to generation. It is only within the last 40 or 50 years that either through the efforts of the missionaries, or the research workers on anthropology or the scholars that certain collections of folk-lore have been made and published. Their folk-songs are superb. As soon as they have a little leisure they will indulge in songs, dances and music. It appears that they snatch every opportunity of life for such festivities. Whether there are changes in the season, domestic occurrences such as marriage or birth or there are traditional offerings or sacrifices to different gods or there is homecoming of the new crops they will indulge in their songs and dances.

There have been collections of some of their songs for *bupla* (marriage); *lagade* (a particular kind of dance akin to *jhumar* dance), *sarhul*, *sohrai* and *karma* festivals in different seasons of the year.

The Santhals have a superb sense of humour. Some of their sayings are typical of their vitality and sense of humour. When a child is born they will say "*Nawa pera ko hec' akana*" meaning "new guests have come" which is an expression for the message that a child is born in the family. To express an acute sense of hunger the Santhal will say "*Lobok' muc' ko geren' kana*" which really means "small ants are eating me up". A polite way of asking a man if he has taken his food will be "*Tala Koram bapla akadea*" the literal meaning of which is "have you married your middle son?" Riddles and problems

are a very good pastime of the Santhals and for this they have got a very rich heritage.

Hazaribagh with its picturesque forests, rivers and hills has a strange fascination for the Santhals. The river Damodar which today lies chained up through the activities of the Damodar Valley Corporation has all along been the very heart-throbs of the life of the Santhals. The Parasnath Hills are their *marang buru* or the sacred hill.

The origin of the appearance of the Santhals in Hazaribagh district can only be guessed. Regarding their original home there has been a belief according to an accepted Santhal tradition that Hihiri, their earliest home, was the *pargana* Ahuri and from there they moved to Khej Kaman and from there to Hara and then to Sasag-Bera and then ultimately to Chai and Champa. Chai and Champa are recognised *parganas* in the district of Hazaribagh. Col. Dalton mentions that traditionally the old fort in Chai was occupied by one Jaura, a Santhal Raja, who destroyed himself and his family on hearing of the approach of a Mohamadan army under Syed Ibrahim Ali alias Malik Baya, a general of Mohammad Tuglak in 1353. The Santhal tradition in Hazaribagh is that from Chai and Champa a portion of their community migrated to the Santhal Parganas.

This theory of the movement of the Santhals cannot be said to be authoritative but there may be some truth in this migration. The river Damodar and the hills and forests of Hazaribagh find a very prominent place in Santhal stories, songs and traditions.

The Santhals are divided into several septs, namely, *hansda*, *murmu*, *kisku*, *hembrom*, *marandi*, *tuddu*, *baska*, *besra*, *pauria*, *Chore*, *bedia*, etc. The first seven of these septs are said to have descended practically from the original father and mother of the Santhals, *Pilchu Horom* and *Pilchu Burhi*, while the remaining septs were added afterwards. The septs have certain pass-words by which they are recognised by one another. But the septs *pauria*, *chore* and *bedia* have no pass-words of their own. It is interesting to observe that one of the pass words of *hansda* sept is *latijhari* which is an important village in Champa *pargana* in Hazaribagh district. This may also be a corroboration of the theory that the original home of the Santhals was in Hazaribagh district.

The Santhals are exogamous and no Santhal can marry within his sept or other sub-septs of his sept. He can marry in any other sept including that of his mother. Regarding the sept of the mother there is a proverb amongst the Santhals signifying that the mother's sept need not be held a taboo for marriage.

Marriage or *bupla* has various forms among the Santhals. Pre-marital sexual intimacy is not unknown and in cases of pregnancy the man concerned is expected to marry the girl or pay a very heavy fine to the village. Polygamy is discouraged. A second marriage is, however, permitted if the wife does not bear a child or the elder brother leaves a widow but even in such cases the second marriage must be done with the permission of the first wife. Here the supremacy of the first wife in the family is well established

The usual marriage forms are (1) *bupla* or *kirin bahu*, (2) *ghardi jawae*, (3) *itut*, (4) *sanga*, (5) *kirin jawae* and (6) *nir-bolok*.

Bupla is the commonest form where marriages are performed with the consent of the parties as also their parents. The bride's price is very nominal, usually Rs. 3. But it is expected that there should be presents of cloth pieces to the girl's people. The price of a divorced woman or a widow is half of the standard rate as it is the tradition that the widow has to be united to the first husband in the next world and the second husband has only a sort of life interest in her.

At the time of actual marriage a thread is passed from the little toe of the bride's left foot to her left ear several times and it is then bound round her arm along with some chillies, rice and *dubgrass*. *Sindur-dan*, i.e., the putting of vermilion mark on the bride's forehead is an essential part of the marriage. It is difficult to say since when *sindur-dan* has become an integral part of the Santhal marriage but here the impact of Hindu tradition is clear.

Ghardi jawae is the form where the bridegroom becomes a part of the family of the bride at least for a period of five years. Usually when girls are difficult to be married off for some reason or other or a deserving homeless or poor boy is found or adopted in the family, this form of marriage is contracted by giving promises of plough, bullocks, rice, etc., to the bride groom. These presents are, however, given to the bridegroom only after five years if he wants to leave the father-in-law's place.

Itut is a form of marriage where a young man forcibly rubs *sindur* (vermilion) on a girl of his choice usually in the village market or at a gathering on some festive occasion. After doing this the young man runs away and waits for the visit of the girl's people to his village. *Sindur-dan* (putting the vermilion on the forehead of the girl) being an integral part of the marriage, the bride's people have got to make the best of the job and exact as much as possible from the bridegroom's people. The bride-price usually becomes double. If, however, the girl still refuses to live with the man, usually she has got to be divorced. *Itut* marriage was also used as an act of vendetta in the olden days. This form of marriage, however, has fallen into disuse.

In this connection it may be mentioned that in the *holi* festival of 1955 six Santhal girls were out for marketing in the bazar of Katihar town in Purnea district when a shopkeeper out of fun put some colour (*abir*) on their forehead. The result was a calamity for the shopkeeper as all the six Santhal girls demanded that he has got to marry them as he has put *abir* on their forehead and ultimately the police had to intervene.

Sanga marriage is meant for the divorced woman and the widow. The actual marriage rite is simple. The bridegroom puts in *sindur* on a *dimbur* flower with his left hand and then he lifts the flower with the same hand and sticks it in the bride's hair.

Kirin-jawae is a convenient form of marriage to meet an inconvenient situation when a girl becomes pregnant or is in love with a young man of her own sept. As inter-marriage within the same sept is a taboo, another young man is procured and given cows, bullocks, paddy, etc., by the young man responsible for the situation. The second young man takes upon himself the odium of the illicit act and the conference called by the village headman usually declares the marriage between the girl and the second man as binding. This social convention leads to the solidarity of the community.

Nir-bolok is a dangerous form of marriage. Here the love-lorn girl just steps into the house of the man she wants to marry and does not come away. Usually she takes a pot of *haria* or rice-beer and does not leave unless absolutely physically assaulted and expelled. Very often the women-folk of the man burns black pepper or chillies to make the woman go or even physically assault the woman. But if the woman stands all this and could stick to the house for one or two days she will have to be considered as the legal wife of the man.

Divorce is permissible but the party not at fault has to be compensated. Divorces are performed in the midst of village assemblies. The husband tears three *sal* leaves in token of separation and upsets a brass pot full of water. If the wife wants to divorce for no fault on her husband's part her people have to return the original bride price paid along with a heavy fine. If the husband wants the divorce, he will have to pay some fine and some customary dues to the woman.

Hindu traditions have a great influence on the customs of child-birth and disposal of the dead. The usual ceremony in Bihar performed on the sixth day of the birth of the child known as *chhathi* is also performed in a Santhal's home. Dead bodies are burnt except in cases of cholera and small-pox. For such deaths the bodies are buried.

Regarding their festivals much has been written before. Santhals have an abandon which is let loose during the festivals. Festivals are

their very life. Some of the festivals are intimately connected with their religious traditions. When the *sal* trees come into flowers during the month of Falgun (February-March) they have their great *baha pooja* which has its opposite number of *bah-parab* amongst the Mundas of Chotanagpur. Some of the festivals like *sohrai* and *sankranti pooja* are common for all the aboriginals of Chotanagpur. During all these festivals tribal or family sacrifices are held and dances and drinking accompanied with songs, flute-music and beating of the drum (*madal*) go on for days and nights, *Sohrai* in the month of Paush (November-December) is called *paush-parban* in Bengal. It is celebrated for the home-coming of paddy, the chief crop of the year. *Sankranti pooja* and *shivaratri* festivals followed by the Santhals are probably borrowed from the Hindu neighbours. The *sankranti* marks the close of the year. The *shivaratri* is marked by fasting and worship of Shiva, the universal God.

Their religion consists of worship of several gods. *Marang-buru* is at the head of the Santhal Pantheon while the other deities are *Thakur*, *Modeko* (Fire God) and *Jal-era*, the deity of the grove which has its counterpart amongst the Oraons and Mundas in the smaller God that presides over the sacred grove known as *sarna*. Each Santhal family has also two sets of Gods of its own, namely, *Ora-bonga*, i.e., household God and "*Abke-bonga*", i.e., great God. They have also now started worshipping Hindu deities like Shiva, Kalimai and Durga.

The Santhals of Hazaribagh district have not attracted as much attention as the Santhals in the Santhal Parganas. The stock is the same and the impact of the present socio-economic forces has brought about changes to the Santhals in the two different areas. It will be recalled that the district of Santhal Parganas was created after the widespread Santhal Insurrection of 1853-55. It was realised that the normal administration was rather unsuitable to the genius of the Santhals. A set of special rules and regulations was made to suit the Santhals. The district of Santhal Parganas was created as a non-regulation district with some special laws. In spite of various touches of modernisation the special rules and regulations of Santhals still remain to a great extent. They particularly refer to the transfer or acquisition of property, mortgage, rent suits, etc.

In Hazaribagh district also there was a big Santhal Insurrection in 1855-56 which had little connection with the rise of the Santhals in the Santhal Parganas. The old records show that the administrators in Chotanagpur Division were very alert that the Santhals in Hazaribagh district during 1855-56 Insurrections did not have any contact with the Santhals elsewhere.

The Santhal rebellion in Hazaribagh district was purely agrarian. The Santhals found themselves faced with an alien rule which little understood them. Their best lands were grabbed by the *mahajans* (money-lenders), or the speculators and they were in perpetual indebtedness. Their tribal laws and *panchayats* were not regarded as sacred. They thoroughly disliked the idea of going to the courts and be tossed about by the hardened court-birds who sucked them well before they could be taken to the lawyer. All these socio-economic causes led to distrust in the administration and this dissatisfaction slowly crystallised. It is really a wonder how the unlettered Santhal Manjhis organised themselves only through a whispering campaign and they rose almost to a man in 1855-56 throughout the district of Hazaribagh.

Their bows and arrows were no match for the guns of the British Army. The zamindars did not give them any help and sided with the ruler. The result was that although the Santhals had a few initial successes here and there the British guns mowed them down. They were hounded from jungle to jungle and were often sandwiched by the British forces. The Santhal villages were burnt mercilessly and their few belongings destroyed. A large number of the Santhal villagers were arrested and were given long term imprisonment. The old records in the Hazaribagh Record Room show that even some Santhal women were put in fetters, marched and put in the prison.

There was again a Santhal rise in 1857 when insurrections broke out throughout the district of Hazaribagh following the mutiny of the Ramgarh Battalion. In this case, of course, the Santhals wanted to recover their previous status, if possible, by utilising the disturbed times. The Santhals gave a lot of trouble to the British Administration in 1857, which practically fell back on Bagodar on the Grand Trunk Road and carried on the remnants of administration from there for some months. The old correspondence records show that the Santhals had come up against at least one detachment and had routed them. It is clear that many of the non-Santhal village headmen had helped the Santhals. The *digwars* and the *ghatwars* who occupied a key position at the hill passages gave considerable help to the Santhals. The movement was, however, put down and Hazaribagh was re-occupied within a short time.

It is a wrong theory that the early Christian Missions had anything to do with the up-rise of the Santhals. The first Christian Missionaries to come to Chotanagpur were the Germans who left Calcutta for Ranchi on February 25, 1845 and travelling by bullock carts *via* Bankura, Purulia and Silli, reached Ranchi on the 2nd November, 1845. They established mission station in Ranchi on the 1st December, 1845. It took them five years to obtain the first converts in 1850. On